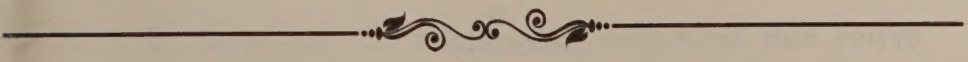
Ross Lanphere

BORN AGAIN, AGAIN

Discovering Your New Identity in Christ

Born Again, *Again!*



Ross Lanphere

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Warning!
Reading this book will do the following:

1. Give you the relationship with God that you've always desired.
2. Help you to see yourself through God's eyes in a whole new way.
3. Help you to see the "destiny" that God was thinking about you on the day that He knit you together in your mother's womb.
4. Will enable you to feel the joy and wonder of having a "brand-new start" in life.
5. Discover how to step into the ministry that God has for you as an ambassador of reconciliation.
6. Give you the ability to stop those "lying voices" that have held you back most of your life.
7. Restore unto you the "victorious life" that God always intended for you.
8. Renew your desire for the Bible, with new passion and vision.
9. Open your eyes to see just how *dead* your "old sinful nature" really is.
10. Cause you to wake up every morning with excitement about your "new life," never to be separated from Jesus ever again.

11. Restore your ability to see the "promises of God" in a new way! That God meant *exactly* what He said to you; that will not change because He truly is the same—yesterday, today, and forever!
12. You will develop "evidence" of a changed life that those who really know you will be envious of.
13. You will *overcome* "controlling sins" that have destroyed you in the past.
14. You will discover how to walk in the *fullness* and *completeness* of who the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit made you become.
15. You will be amazed at the process of "as He is, so are we in *this world*" (1 John 4:17).

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I also want to thank my church family, Family Life Center Foursquare Church. Thank you for letting me "experiment" with you as we have lived out our new identity together.

Introduction

I'm born again, again!

That's how I felt when I realized what it truly means to be born again. I realize that most of my life I only understood the *first half* of the Gospel that Jesus died for my sins.

This book was written to help you understand the *second half* of the Gospel story. The *good news* of the Gospel story—when Jesus died on the cross, that you died with Him!

When Jesus rose from the grave into *newness of life*, you rose with Him!

If you received this book, hopefully, it's because you just made the *best decision* of your life.

- You prayed to the Father
- Asked for forgiveness of your sins
- Asked Jesus to come into your life
- To be my Lord and Savior

Now you've become "born again," as a brand-new creation in Christ.

Second Corinthians 5:17 says, "If any man is in Christ, he's a new creation the old has passed away and behold all things have become new."

Imagine if I told you, you could draw a line on the ground and when you step across that line,

- all your *past* is now gone;
- all that you ever did that was negative no longer matters;
- all that was done to you negatively can no longer affect your life;
- it's a *starting line* into a new life, a new beginning, and you get to choose who you want to be from now on with the help of the Holy Spirit who is now in you.

Would you step across the line and become a new creation in Christ? A brand-new *you* that never existed before?

That's what being *born again* means!

This book was written to help you discover just what happened when you prayed that prayer. It was probably something like this:

Heavenly Father, thank you for sending Jesus to die for my sins—past, present, and future. Dear Jesus, forgive me of my sins and come into my life and make me new. I give my life to you and make you my Lord and my Savior, in Jesus' name I pray. Amen.

"If you are already a Christian."

If you are already a Christian as I was, this is the best news you have heard since the day you were born again! This book was written for you also.

You are about to discover something I learned from Pastor Bill Johnson years ago that has stayed in my heart to this day. Bill says, "He's better than we think! So we have to change the way we think!"

This book hopefully causes that thinking process that makes you say to others, "I feel like I've been born again, again!"

Chapter 1

The Gospel Is Rigged! (And God Did It)

I've had many frustrations over the years as a born-again believer. I've heard many things taught that just didn't quite line up with what I was seeing in the Bible. For instance, I knew that Jesus said, "I will never leave you or forsake you." That's a wonderful promise in Hebrews 13:5.

But then I've heard others teach that when we sin, fellowship with God is broken until we repent and get right with God again. These *two things* don't line up! So I always wondered, "Where does He go? Does He have a room in my heart that He goes to and won't come out to talk to me until I repent? Say I'm sorry?"

Here's something else that didn't line up for me: the Bible says in Hebrews 9:22 that "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness." But others were telling me that an *apology* was just as good. I don't think so! Hebrews 10:10 says, "We *have* been sanctified (made holy) through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ *once for all*!"

They told me before I came to Jesus that when I became born again, all my sins would be forgiven—past, present, and future. Many things like this confused me because it seemed like a bait-and-switch philosophy.

They would say that "Jesus forgives all your sin—past, present, and future, but *now you* have to work on your sin." This is *not* the Gospel.

With their thinking, how will I know when I did it right? How will I know when it was enough? Will I feel it? Will He tell me? Was Jesus shedding His blood *once* not enough? So now it's up to me to finish it? Killing my old sinful nature? And what about the fact that He said He would never "forsake me"? *Forsake* means "He abandons me." He said He wouldn't do that! I've tried and tried to stop sinning, and nothing worked. I came to Jesus hoping He could give me hope for a better life. But now you're telling me that "I" have to do it? (Are you depressed yet?)

No wonder people are coming in the front door and leaving a few weeks later out the back. Look at what the body of Christ is doing to them.

This is *not* the Gospel! Listen, we don't have to just accept or overlook our frustrations. Jesus said the *truth*: the Word of God will set you free!

Look at what the word says and what you're feeling. The Bible will back itself up; you don't have to defend it. There will be many verses that either say the same thing or speak the same thought. So always look into the Word of God and what it really says.

The Gospel begins with your forgiveness, you're clean, you're a new creation and you are the righteousness of God

in Christ Jesus. There is nothing left of a "sin nature" in you anymore! Period. The truth is the real Gospel, the real good news is rigged! And God rigged it!

> *Knowing this, that our old man was crucified with Him, that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves of sin.* (Romans 6:6)

When Jesus was crucified on the cross, your old sinful nature died with Him (when He died, you died).

> *I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.* (Galatians 2:20)

> *For he who has died has been freed from sin.* (Romans 6:7)

> *Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new.* (2 Corinthians 5:17)

You are *now* a new creation! Your past is *gone*! Your sin nature is *dead* and *buried*!

> *For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.* (2 Corinthians 5:21)

Now you are a new creation with no past; sins were forgiven. There's nothing of a sin nature in you *anymore*! You are the righteousness of God in Christ. Of course, you're righteous; you are in Christ! How could you be anything less?

Here's the "rigged" part.

> *Being confident of this very thing, that He who has begun a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ;* (Philippians 1:6)

"He" (capital HE), God, began to work in you the moment you became born again.

> *For you were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light* (Ephesians 5:8)

He took you out of Adam (darkness) dead in sin.
Crucified your sinful nature.
Buried you with Christ.
Raised the two of you together.
And now you live in Christ,
The righteousness of God!

> *For it is God who works in you both to will and to do for His good pleasure.* (Philippians 2:13)

See, it's God who works. Not you! He's changing your *will* and *do*. And He's doing it "for His good pleasure."

> *Now may the God of peace Himself sanctify you completely; and may your whole spirit, soul, and body be preserved blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. He who calls you is faithful, who also will do it.* (1 Thessalonians 5:23–24)

God Himself is sanctifying you completely. He who calls you is *faithful* and catch this, "He will also do it!"

Can you see that this Gospel, this good news, is *rigged*? So always keep in the back of your mind, *God is at work in my life! He will never leave me or forsake me!*

> *For in Him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily; and you are complete in Him, who is the head of all principality and power.* (Colossians 2:9–10)

I'm *complete* in Him. God gives us everything up front the moment we give our lives to Christ and come into a relationship with Him. Immediately we receive the "mind of Christ."

> *For who has known the mind of the Lord that he may instruct Him?" But we have the mind of Christ.* (1 Corinthians 2:16)

> *As His divine power has given to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of Him who called us by glory and virtue, by which have been given to us exceedingly great and precious promises, that through these you may be partakers of the divine nature, having escaped the corruption that is in the world through lust.* (2 Peter 1:3–4)

He gives us everything we need for life and godliness in the knowledge of Him.

The Holy Spirit is given to us by Jesus to teach us what we have been given. There's no timeline on when it has to happen. But we can have it as fast as we want. The Holy Spirit is making us just like Jesus; it's His promise!

> *Love has been perfected among us in this: that we may have boldness in the day of judgment; because as He is, so are we in this world.* (1 John 4:17)

As He is, so are we in *this world*. And He's doing it for "His good pleasure"!

Graham Cooke says, "Grace is the empowering presence of God that enables you to become the person that He sees when He looks at you."

He's in you now to empower you to become like Him. It's rigged! So now when God looks at you, He doesn't see anything wrong because everything that was wrong with you He killed on the cross! Now, when He looks at you, He sees what's missing from your life. He sees we don't know who we are in Christ, our *new identity*. That's why He sent the Holy Spirit to teach you who you are in Christ and what now belongs to you in the name of Jesus. He's better than we think! So we have to change the way we think.

Discussion Time—Chapter 1

1. Talk with someone of your frustrations with what you heard from some Christian leaders and what you were reading in the Bible.
2. Talk with someone of what it means that the Gospel is rigged.
3. Meditate on and discuss the following:

   Romans 6:6
   Galatians 2:20
   2 Corinthians 5:17
   2 Corinthians 5:21
   Philippians 1:6
   Philippians 2:13
   1 Thessalonians 5:23–24

Chapter 2

It Is for Freedom That Jesus Set Us Free!

In John 8:36, the Bible says, "Therefore, if the Son makes you free, you shall be free indeed." There is a wonderful desire in the heart of God to set every one of His children free from legalism. That we totally understand the *freedom* that belongs to us in Jesus.

Galatians 5:1 says, "Stand fast, therefore, in the liberty by which Christ has made us free and do not be entangled

again with a yoke of bondage." Jesus paid a tremendous price to win us this freedom. So that we could know Him, that we could walk with Him, without any rules or regulations that man would try to put us under. If you read the writings of the apostles in the New Covenant, so much is about how important it is to avoid legalism and religiosity.

It was a major fight in the body of Christ (the early church), and it continues even to today. There's a real hunger right now for the "good news" of the Gospel, and God needs you as an ambassador of hope.

In the Old Covenant, there were the people of God who didn't understand that the New Covenant was to completely replace the Old Covenant. So, therefore, they were always trying to get new Jesus believers to come under this "law" or to keep these "rules" trying to bring the New Covenant believers back under the Old Covenant laws.

In Romans 10:3–4, Paul says,

> *For they being ignorant of God's righteousness and seeking to establish their own righteousness have not submitted to the righteousness of God. For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.*

Paul, Peter, James, and John constantly told the new believers in Jesus there are no rules! There's only the law of love!

Jesus said the law is fulfilled in these two commandments:

> *Then one of the scribes came, and having heard them reasoning together, perceiving that He had answered them well, asked Him, "Which is the first commandment of all?" Jesus answered him, "The first of all the commandments is: 'Hear, O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one. And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, with all your mind, and with all your strength.'" This is the first commandment. And the second, like it, is this: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself." There is no other commandment greater than these.* (Mark 12:28–31)

Those in the Old Covenant loved the law but couldn't keep it. Jesus fulfilled the law and gave us the *law of love* in the New Covenant. *You* are in the New Covenant and learning the "law of love."

The New Covenant is so much more powerful! So much more awesome that it completely obliterates the Old Covenant and makes it of no effect. Jesus didn't come to attach the New Covenant to the old one. He came to absolutely 100 percent—replace it with the New! The Old Covenant was based on animal sacrifices, with a system of rules and regulations. Jesus replaces it by becoming "the sacrifice" as the only sinless human being that has ever lived. Jesus was crucified for all sin—past, present, and

future—so that the written requirements of the law might be fulfilled in Him.

So there is nothing we can add to this salvation, and nothing we can do to make ourselves more acceptable or more presentable to God. You are going to experience this new, unchanging covenant in all of God's glory! This great and glorious *good news* is so captivating that it causes you to want to read your Bible just to know Him more!

It's so motivating, this good news, that you won't be able to keep it to yourself. It will spill out to all your friends just because of this new atmosphere you carry. It's not about what we have to *do*; it's about what Jesus has *done*! That's the magnificence of our story. This good news of "who we are in Christ" and "what belongs to us now in the name of Jesus"! Here are some *new creation declarations* that will teach you your new identity as a born-again believer in Christ.

New Creation Declaration

- I am a born-again believer in Jesus Christ.
- I've been taken out of the darkness and put into His marvelous light (Ephesians 5:8).
- I am a new creation. Old things (past) have passed away and behold, all things have become new (my future) (2 Corinthians 5:17).
- God made Jesus to become sin for me that I might become the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21)

- I am the righteousness of God; He gave it to me as a gift (Romans 5:17).
- God no longer sees what's wrong with me, because Jesus killed off everything wrong in my old sinful nature.
- God now only see's what's missing from my experience with Him, and Jesus sent the Holy Spirit to give me that experience!
- Grace to me is the empowering presence of God in me that enables me to become the person that God see's when He looks at me.
- My behavior has nothing to do with what God did. I can't improve on it; I can only embrace it in its fullness (Colossians 2:9–10).
- He who began a good work in me is going to complete it (Philippians 1:6).
- It is God who works in me both to *will* and to *do* of His good pleasure (Philippians 2:13).
- God is sanctifying me completely. He who has called me is faithful who also *will do it.* (1 Thessalonians 5:23–24).
- I'm *not* progressively changing from sinner to saint, it's a one-step program (Ephesians 5:8).
- I no longer have to work on what's wrong with me in sin. I'm only learning who I am as a righteous man or woman of God.
- There are no rules or regulations on me to do. I'm called to obey the *law of love* (Mark 12:29–31).
- It's not about what I must *do*, it's about what Jesus has already *done*!

- There is, therefore, now *no condemnation* for those who are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1).
- I am in Christ! That's my *new identity*.
- The law of the spirit of life in Christ Jesus has *set me free* from the law of sin and death (Romans 8:2).
- So I will look into the eyes of Jesus every day and say thank you Lord for all that you've done!

Everything about your new life in Christ hinges upon you being able to see yourself as a new creation. That's the truth of God's Word and every other voice that speaks to you must be rejected.

Believe these declarations, speak them to yourself out loud even if right now you don't believe it or feel it. The Bible says, "Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the Word of God" (Romans 10:17). The Holy Spirit has been given to you. "He's living in you to teach you and remind you of what you're learning" (John 14:26). It's His job to bring you to the place where you recognize the voice that's speaking to you about your newfound righteousness, that's God. All other voices must be rejected.

> *There is, therefore, now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.* (Romans 8:1)

No condemnation, that's the grace of God.

God no longer sees what's wrong with you, because everything that was wrong with you Jesus killed it off. So

God only sees what's missing in your relationship with Him, and Jesus sent the Holy Spirit to give you that experience! Think of your life like this: when you were "born again," it's like you became a brand-new computer (illustration), but you are filled with "old software" like Windows XP. God made *you* new, but your *thinking* needs to be updated. That's the Holy Spirit's job! And, that's the purpose of this book, to begin the renewing of your mind.

You are no longer a *sinner* because your old nature that was sinful was crucified with Christ. See Galatians 2:20 and Romans 6:6, but you still have sin habits (old software). But the good news is, habits can be broken. The miracle you are going to watch happen in your very own heart is, you're *not* going to focus on trying to stop sinning, your *not* going to think about sin. Now you're *only* going to learn about your newfound righteousness, your new life in Jesus! You are going to see your own life change. Yes, sin will fade away. Yes, your choices will change; your habits will change. It will happen as you discover just how righteous Jesus has already made you. Right here, right now, you are never going to become *more righteous* than you are right now because it has *nothing* to do with your behavior. It has nothing to do with your performance.

Christianity is *not* a behavior-modification program. There is only one thing that makes you righteous: it's the blood of Jesus. Second Corinthians 5:21 says, "He made 'Him' (Jesus) who knew no sin, to become sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him." Romans 5:17 says, "For if by the one man's offense death reigned through the one, much more *those* who receive

abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness will reign in life through the one, Jesus Christ." That one man's offense was Adam.

Righteousness is a *gift*. God gave you that gift when you opened your heart and came into a relationship with Jesus. You did nothing to earn it, you only received it and it happened when Jesus set you free from sin!

> *I can't be any more righteous than I already am!*
>
> —Pastor Ross Lanphere
> Easter Sunday, April 20, 2014

Ref: "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21).

Discussion Time—Chapter 2

1. Read through the new creation declaration sheet and try to explain it to someone. (Don't worry how well you do. The more you practice, the better you will become at explaining it.)
2. Discuss with someone how 2 Corinthians 5:17 and 21 have opened your understanding of your new identity in Christ.

Chapter 3

Let Me Explain What Happened

First, a question: How many sins do you have to commit to become a *sinner*?

Everybody always says "one!" The answer is *none*, *zero*.

Remember this for the rest of your life. What makes you a sinner is *who you are in, not what you do*. You were in Adam, and that's what made you a sinner. You were born into sin from your mother's womb. God took you out of Adam and crucified your old sinful nature and you are, therefore, born again in Christ as a new creation. When God put you in Christ as a new creation, you became the righteousness of God in Christ. What makes you righteous is *you* are *in Christ*.

Ephesians 5:8 says, "For you were once darkness, but *now* you are *light in the Lord*. Walk as children of light." Some people think Christianity is a 12-step program. This is not the case. God took you out of sin in Adam and in "one step" put you in Christ. Romans 6:6 says that your old man of sin was crucified with Him on the cross, that the body of sin (your old sinful nature) might be done away

with, that we should no longer be slaves of sin. Verse 7 says, "For He who has died has been freed from sin." So the question is, do you believe what the Bible says? Do you believe that when you asked for forgiveness from your sin that God at that moment, in one step, took you out of Adam and crucified your old nature on the cross with Christ?

Do you believe Romans 6:8 that says, "Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we shall also live with Him"? Paul tells us in verse 5, "For if we have been united together in the likeness of His death, certainly we also shall be in the likeness of His resurrection."

What the Bible is saying is when Jesus died, your old sinful nature died with Him on the cross. In Galatians 2:20, Paul declares that he's been *crucified* with *Christ*. When Jesus was buried you were buried (your old sinful nature) with Him.

In Romans 6:4, we read, "Therefore, we were buried with Him through baptism into death, that just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life." This is not you being water baptized. It has to do with your old nature buried, and you resurrecting with Jesus into a new way of life. This is what happened when you were "born again." This is God killing and burying your old sinful nature, never to be heard from again. This is you being resurrected into a new way of life as a "new creation," the righteousness of God in Christ.

Your life is now in Christ! Of course, you're the righteousness of God, you are *in Christ*, how could you be

anything less? So, Romans 6:11 says, "Likewise you also, reckon yourselves to be dead indeed to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord." There it is again! Over and over, the Bible paints us the picture of our new life being lived out *in Christ.*

When Jesus died on the cross, you died with Him. To see yourself this way is your new identity. To see yourself this way will help you to renew your thinking. To see yourself this way "programs" you with the software updates of your new identity. My friend Rich B. says, "If you don't know who you are in Jesus, you'll never know who Jesus is in you." It's so important that you *see* and *think* of yourself this way because negative voices from the devil are going to try to tell you none of this happened and nothing has changed.

There's a battle now being waged for your thoughts. Nothing has to be won, the devil has already lost you! There's nothing of sin left in you, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God. Jesus has rendered him utterly defeated!

Your New Mind-Set

> *If then you were raised with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ is, sitting at the right hand of God. Set your mind on things above, not on things on the earth. For you died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God.* (Colossians 3:1–3)

You are hidden *in Christ, in God*. Sounds like a pretty great place to live the rest of your life.

It's so vital that you see that nothing negative from your past can follow you from the cross. Your life on this side of the cross was meant to be lived in "newness of life." Jesus said in John 10:10, "The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly." Jesus made a way by crucifying your past that you would not have to live with anything negative.

You Are Not a Victim of Your Past

Nothing that you did, nothing that was done to you came out of the grave. When Christ rose, you rose with Him as a "new creation," all the old, negative past is gone. Never to be thought of or dealt with again. God doesn't want you to be a born-again Christian and live in guilt or shame. He doesn't want you to live the rest of your life as a victim of the abuse of others in your past. He made a way for you to have a "new start"—an abundant new life. Think of the apostle Paul. He used to persecute Christians. God used him to help teach these revelations to all Christians as he heard the Holy Spirit lead him.

Think of the demoniac in the Bible, you know the "naked guy" who lived in the cemetery, the guy that had a *legion* of demons in him before Jesus cast them out? Now there's a guy with a past! But many believe he was so transformed as a "new creation" that many of the people of that region became "born again" after they heard his story. God

wants the negative of your past dead and buried, crucified on the cross. But the life you now live to be so abundant that when people hear your story, they come to know Him as you know Him. That's called your testimony.

Your testimony consists of three parts:

1. This is my life before I came to Jesus.
2. This is how I came to Jesus.
3. This is my life since I came into a *relationship* with Him.

It's a *relationship*, not a religion. You are in Christ, the righteousness of God. You're never going to become more righteousness than you are right now. Here are some "righteousness declarations." Say them out loud, look up the associated scriptures, say it like you believe it because it's absolutely true of you. This is your new identity in Jesus!

Righteousness Declarations

- I have received the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness (Romans 5:17).
- I will reign in this life as a king (Romans 5:17).
- I am the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus (2 Corinthians 5:21).
- There is, therefore, now no condemnation because I'm in Him and He's in me (Romans 8:1–2).
- I am a new creation in Christ Jesus (2 Corinthians 5:17).

- Old things have passed away and all things have become new (2 Corinthians 5:17).
- The righteous (that's me) shall live by faith (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38; Habakkuk 2:4).
- I've been crucified with Christ, nevertheless, I live not I but Christ lives in me, the life I now live, I live by faith in the Son of God who loves me, who gave Himself for me, so I'll live for Him for all eternity (Galatians 2:20).
- The righteous are as bold as a lion (Proverbs 28:1).
- The righteous leave an inheritance to their children's children (Proverbs 13:22).
- Many are the afflictions of the righteous, *but* the Lord delivers them out of them *all* (Psalm 34:19).
- He who follows righteousness and mercy finds friends (Proverbs 21:21).
- He who follows righteousness and kindness finds life, righteousness, and honor (Proverbs 21:21).
- A righteous man walks in His integrity, blessed are his children after him (Proverbs 20:7).
- The *memory* of the righteous is *blessed*, but the name of the wicked will *rot* (Proverbs 10:7).
- The righteous gives and does not spare (Proverbs 21:26).
- When the righteous thrive, a city rejoices (Proverbs 11:10).
- The effective fervent prayer of a righteous man avails much (James 5:16).

Jesus crucified our sins and our sin nature!

—Pastor Ross Lanphere
Sunday, October 22, 2017

Discussion Time—Chapter 3

1. Explain to someone what makes you a sinner.
2. Explain and discuss how Christianity is a "one-step program" (Ephesians 5:8).
3. Discuss with someone why you don't ever have to deal with your "past."
4. Practice giving your "three-step testimony."
5. Read "righteousness declarations" every day this week.

Chapter 4

Hope: The Missing Ingredient

We clearly see our life differently now. No longer obsessed with dealing with our sins but believing what God has done.

There is nothing of the "sin nature" that is still alive in you. You are a completely new creation; you are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus.

Hopefully, now you can see that God wants you to be obsessed with your new identity in Christ.

The *wonder* of the Gospel story is what brings about such hope. We begin to see ourselves as God sees us in grace. We come alive to what Jesus *did*, not what we must *do*. "Hope" fills our heart when we hear the truth of the Gospel. That which seemed impossible to achieve in changing our life to match up with what we see, now seems, possible because of what Jesus did. It can come true for us.

The wonderful good news births *hope* in our hearts that motivates us to trust in what the Word of God says. But so many times we come to the cross filled with hope.

We ask for forgiveness and receive Jesus into our lives. We feel so clean, so new, and we leave with a feeling that the weight of our sin has been lifted from us. Only to experience the next day what seems to be that nothing really happened.

"Here's where we go wrong."

When you come back to share with those who led you to Jesus, they say something along these lines: "Well, you are forgiven," "You are saved," "You are one day going to go to heaven." *But now* that you're a Christian, we need to help you work on your sins, cleaning up your life.

"Hold it right there!"

I believe this is why we see so many today who get saved, Sunday after Sunday after Sunday. They say, "I need to get saved because I keep sinning!"

You see, they don't understand what Jesus did and their leaders don't either. So they believe that Jesus started a work in you, but now you must do your part. They teach new believers as if, yes, you are saved, but now we must work on your behavior.

So when do you feel *good enough*? When do you know you've done enough? When do you feel like you have completely killed your sinful nature?

YOU DON'T!

This "religious" teaching is why we're in such a mess. The Gospel is you *trust* what the Word says about your salvation and you *trust* what the word of God says about your sanctification.

Sanctification means set apart or made holy. Righteousness is what makes you holy, and God gave it to you as a gift. Here's the proof:

> *For if by the one man's offense death reigned through the one, much more those who receive abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness will reign in life through the One, Jesus Christ.* (Romans 5:17)
>
> *Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new.* (2 Corinthians 5:17) (That includes *you*).
>
> *For He made Him (Jesus) who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.* (2 Corinthians 5:21)

See, many believers and leaders do really well at telling you who you are as you come to the cross. They are very good at telling you what took place when Jesus died on the

cross, was buried, and rose from the dead. But we miss the fact that the same "good news" applies to us in life after the cross as well.

One night, about 3:00 a.m., the Holy Spirit woke me up and said these words to me in that still small voice, "Therefore from now on we regard no one according to the flesh!" I knew I had to get up and write it down and later look it up.

When I looked it up in the Bible, what the Holy Spirit spoke to me just blew me away! It's 2 Corinthians 5:16, the verse right before the one that says we're a new creation and our past is gone (II Corinthians 5:17)! The Holy Spirit immediately spoke to me and said, "From now on, I want you to speak and teach born-again believers as if they are already there—because they are!" Immediately my mind went to Colossians 2:9–10, which says:

> For in Him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily; and you are complete in Him, who is the head of all principality and power.

You are filled with the godhead bodily, and you are *complete* in Him. Complete! It means finished! There's no more that has to happen to you, other than you learning just how complete you already are! Can you see how that brings people *hope*! That's what the Holy Spirit was showing me.

The reason people leave a few weeks after they get saved is that they think, "It didn't work for me!" That is such a lie of the devil, but it works very well at getting people to give up.

New believers who aren't taught about their "new identity in Christ" are vulnerable to the lies of the enemy. They think, *I tried and tried to stop sinning, but I just can't do it! I read my Bible! I went to church! I prayed! I did everything they told me!*

How unfortunate! This has to change!!

Will you help me?

I want you to read this book over and over until the truth of the Gospel breeds "hope" in you. The kind of hope where you want to give it away to everyone.

Talk about the "line on the ground," talk about being born-again and what it truly means. Talk to them as if they're already saved, sanctified, set apart, and righteous. Tell them what you see in their lives that they can't see. It's called *prophecy*.

In 1 Corinthians 14:3, it says, "But he who prophesies speaks edification and exhortation and comfort to men."

We call it "calling out the gold."

Tell them what God is telling you that will edify them, exhorts them, and comforts them. Anyone can "call out the dirt." It takes no prophetic gift to tell people what's wrong with them (as if they don't already know). So tell

them what you see, or what God's speaking to you about them, that motivates them to be more and more like who the Bible says *they already are*!

By the way, 1 Corinthians 14:31 shows you that you have God's permission to speak prophetically:

"For you can all prophesy one by one, that all may learn and all may be encouraged." Who doesn't need that?

Let me show you another verse in the Bible that helps me to see the process of giving new believers hope.

> 1 John 3:2-3: *Beloved, now we are children of God; and it has not yet been revealed what we shall be, but we know that when He is revealed, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is. And everyone who has this hope in Him purifies himself, just as He is pure.*

Did you see it? And *everyone* who has this "hope" in Him (Jesus) *purifies himself*! That's what the Holy Spirit was showing me at that 3:00 a.m. wake-up call.

You *can't* punish people into purity … but you *can* hope them into it! That's grace! The empowering presence of God that enables me to become the person that He sees when He looks at me!

It brings hope!
It brings vision!

It brings true repentance!

Because they see it! Then they say, "This is what I want!" I don't know why I was hanging on to that old sinful behavior. This is who I've always wanted to be; I just never knew how to get there! If you have your Bible open, go a few more verses to 1 John 3:4–9:

> *Whoever commits sin also commits lawlessness, and sin is lawlessness. And you know that He was manifested to take away our sins, and in Him there is no sin. Whoever abides in Him does not sin. Whoever sins has neither seen Him nor known Him.*
>
> *Little children, let no one deceive you. He who practices righteousness is righteous, just as He is righteous. He who sins is of the devil, for the devil has sinned from the beginning. For this purpose the Son of God was manifested, that He might destroy the works of the devil. Whoever has been born of God does not sin, for His seed remains in him; and he cannot sin, because he has been born of God.*

Whoever is born of God *does not* sin. Why? Because Jesus killed off every sinful thing about you on the cross. There's *nothing* sinful about the *new you*!

You may have some "sinful habits" that need to be broken (habits can be broken). But *you* are no longer a sinner, you are a saint! And *you* are a new creation, the righteousness of God *in Christ.*

You're *in Christ*

The *process* of seeing yourself the way He sees you is the process that will set you free. Because Jesus has *paid* for you to be *totally free*. It's *not* behavior modification. It's you seeing and believing what the Word of God says about you. And always remember—it's *already done*!

Discussion Time—Chapter 4

1. Discuss the whole "bait-and-switch" experience that so many Christians have unfortunately experienced.
2. Discuss why there's nothing for us to "now" work on, except for learning "who we are now!"
3. Discuss with someone:

   Romans 5:17
   2 Corinthians 5:17
   2 Corinthians 5:21

4. Practice "calling out the gold" in your discussion group. (Tell them who they are now and what God sees when He looks at them.)

Chapter 5

Winning in Life

Jesus makes us available for receiving two wonderful offers:

1. He offers to set us free from the "penalty of sin."
2. He offers to set us free from the "power of sin."

Both of these offers are made at the cross on the day we became "born-again." Both are made with exactly the same terms as well. The terms are: We accept them on the basis of letting Jesus completely do it all.

Every Christian has accepted the first offer but unfortunately not many have accepted the second offer. They mistakenly think as I did for years. That I must have a part in overcoming the power of sin. I mistakenly believed that my efforts, my will, my determination, and my strength were going to be "helped" by the power of Christ in me.

I thought surely this is how you overcome sin. Surely, this is the way to becoming more like Christ. But little did I realize that this thinking would be what held me back, never completely overcoming the power of sin in my life. I realize

now that just as if I thought that my salvation had something to do with *my effort*. I would be doomed to hell. The same is true if I think anything on my part, anything of my effort depends on me helping in overcoming the power of sin as well.

Someone once said to me, "Salvation is free but righteousness and sanctification are costly." This thinking has most of the Body of Christ caught in a helpless trap that keeps them in the hopelessness of "Performance Christianity."

Most Christians sadly have had the experience of winning on Sunday and loosing on Monday. Confessing their sin and then trying to do their best. Getting excited by a message, a book, a video, a conference only to see it all erode quickly back to life as normal. Even though this *is* the common experience of most Christians, this is *not* the Gospel!

The Gospel is the good news! Winning in life requires us to let Jesus do it all. Here's a radical thought for you. What if I told you that Jesus does *not* want to be *your helper*? It's not "I do the best I can, and Jesus makes up the difference." It's not "I try to change my life with Jesus's help." Just like Jesus didn't want my help in salvation. We know this! How crazy to tell anyone that Jesus died on the cross for me, but I wasn't that bad when I became a Christian. How ridiculous. I was a sinner doomed to hell with no hope outside of what Jesus did in dying *for me*! Shedding His innocent blood for me so that I could be forgiven!

The life that wins depends totally and exclusively on Jesus. Once you receive Jesus Christ into your life it

becomes His responsibility to keep you from the power of sin. He pledges to do so.

> ***For sin shall not have dominion over you, for you are not under law but under grace.*** (Romans 6:14)

You are not under law—what's that mean? I'm *not* under the Old Covenant law where *I* do it with *His* help, but under grace. Jesus does it all in and through me.

> *For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and seeking to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted to the righteousness of God. For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.* (Romans 10:3–4)

Christ is the end of the law. Period.

Christ is in me wanting to live through me. No longer a visitational relationship based on my performance, but now a habitational relationship where I'm under grace.

What's grace? Simply put, it's the empowering presence of God that enables me to become the person that He sees when He looks at me. Second Corinthians 12:9 states, "And He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness.' Therefore most gladly I will rather boast in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me."

Paul asked Jesus to take away this attack on his life and Jesus said, "My grace is sufficient for you." We are not to ask Him to make His grace sufficient for us, He tells us it *is* already so! Our part is to simply take Him at His word and say, "Thank you, Jesus!"

"Spiritual warfare" for us is not us defeating the enemy, it's us discovering the majesty and supremacy of our God. We don't pray for victory, but rather praise Him from victory! Why? Because the battle is over, sin has already been defeated!

Look at Philippians 3:8–9:

> *Yet indeed I also count all things loss for the excellence of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them as rubbish, that I may gain Christ and be found in Him, not having my own righteousness, which is from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which is from God by faith.*

Not having my *own righteousness* which is from the law. But the righteousness which is from God by faith.

So again, Romans 6:14, "For sin shall not have dominion over you, for you are not under law but under grace," and Romans 6:17, "For he who has died has been freed from sin." You're freed from sin if you died with Christ. What died? Your old sinful nature! Romans 6:11 says, "Likewise you also, reckon yourselves to be dead indeed

to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord." So if you want a life that wins, see yourself like God sees you, think about yourself like God thinks about you. Look at 2 Corinthians 1:20: "For all the promises of God in Him are Yes, and in Him Amen, to the glory of God through us."

All the promises are yes and amen to the glory of God but through us! Jesus does not want to be your *helper*, He wants to be your *life*! Paul reminded the Philippians in chapter 1, verse 21, "For to me, to live is Christ, and to die is gain." For me to live *is* Christ! Paul did NOT say:

> For me to live is to be Christlike.
> For me to live is to live with Christ's help.
> For me to live is to serve Christ.

No! Paul brings a whole new understanding that Jesus gives us the gift of Himself. And this, my friend, is the gateway to the "Winning life!" Look closely at this chart: He died as me—I rose as Him.

He Died as Me—I Rose as Him

God takes us out of Adam. We were dead in Sin. What makes you a Sinner is who you're in not what you do. *You were born in Sin.*

(Romans 5:17)

We were *crucified together* with Christ. He died as me. He killed my old sinful nature.

(Romans 6:6; Galatians 2:20)

We were *buried together*; our old sinful nature stays in the grave never to be heard from again!

(Romans 6:6; Ephesians 2:4–8)

We were *raised together*. I'm "born again."
A new creation, the righteousness of God.
(Romans 6:6; 2 Corinthians. 5:17, 21)

Now we are "one" *together* and walk in newness of life. Not I but Christ. For me to live "is" Christ! We *live together* as "one"!
(Romans 6:4; Philippians 1:21;
1 John 4:17; Galatians 2:20)

I used to see my relationship with Christ as if "He was one and I was another." That Jesus is my savior who is ready to come close:

To help me in time of need.
To give me power.
To give me strength.

I no longer see our relationship as if "He were one and I was another," but now Christ wants us to understand that

our body is His,
our mind is His,
our will is His,
our spirit is His.

And not merely His, but literally a part of Him. We are the body of Christ. So I started remembering Galatians 2:20: "I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me."

I started seeing we were crucified together. We were buried together, and now we live together. Not I but Christ. We live together as *one*! So, "For me to live *is* Christ!" (Philippians 1:21). You see me, you see Jesus. First John 4:17 says, "Because as He is, so are we in this world."

Jesus does not want to be your helper. He wants to be your life! He sent the Holy Spirit to be our helper, this is His job, but Jesus wants to live His life through us! Think of it like this. As I am writing this book, I'm using a pen. I don't want the pen's help; I want to *use* the pen. I know the dreams and plans that I have as I create this book. I don't want the pens to help in thinking what it would think, but I want to use it to write my story.

In the same way, Jesus has done everything for Him to be able to give you the "abundant life" He promised. Let's look at a few scriptures:

> *Being confident of this very thing, that He who has begun a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ.* (Philippians 1:6)
>
> *For it is God who works in you both to will and to do for His good pleasure.* (Philippians 2:13)
>
> *Now may the God of peace Himself sanctify you completely; and may your whole spirit, soul, and body be preserved blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. He who calls you is faithful, who also will do it.* (1 Thessalonians 5:23–24)

Every day when you wake up shout boldly, "For me, to live *is* Christ!"

Discussion Time—Chapter 5

1. Discuss the meaning of "winning on Sunday, losing on Monday."
2. Discuss the meaning of "Jesus does not want to be *your* helper; He wants to be your life."
3. Discuss the sheet on page 52-53, "He died as me—I rose as Him."
4. What is the true meaning of Philippians 1:21: "For me, to live *is* Christ."

Chapter 6

He's Given Us All Things (There's No More Coming)

Early on in my Christian walk, I began to discover the vast difference between the way Christians talk the songs we sing, the prayers we pray, and what the Word of God actually says. Things like,

- He's given us all things that pertain to life and godliness. *But we act like He hasn't!*
- By His stripes, I'm healed. *But we pray like we're not!*
- I am filled with the fullness of the godhead bodily, and I am complete in Him. *But we keep praying for more!*
- Because as He is, so are we in this world. *But we think we're not!*
- I've received the gift of righteousness. *But I keep trying to earn it!*
- I've been crucified with Christ. *But I think I have to clean up my old sinful nature!*

On and on, so many contradictions between what the Bible says and how we live our lives, even the songs that we sing:

- Asking Him to come. *When He never left!*
- Asking for more of His presence. *When we're filled with the fullness of God!*
- Asking as a Christian for more cleansing. *When there's nothing more to cleanse!*
- Asking for Him to heal us. *When it's already done!*
- Asking as a Christian for deliverance. *When we've already been delivered!*
- Asking for Him to do what He's already promised to do. *Rather than believing what He said!*

I know it sounds right. I know these precious saints mean well. The reality is that it's Satan's way of keeping us on the *performance* treadmill going nowhere. Always feeling like you don't have it yet. You're not quite good enough. You haven't done enough, try harder! Let me ask you, "When do you ever know that you did enough?. When do you feel like it's over?" You never do! That's the trap that so many Christians are caught up in today. The *trap* is called "your performance."

Listen, the *performance* is over. Jesus did it! He perfectly performed so that God could give you all things. Jesus completed everything that was necessary for you and me to be restored back into a relationship with our Heavenly Father. It's what the plan was from the foundation of the

world. *You* are filled with the fullness of the godhead bodily and *You* are *complete* in Him. (Colossians 2:9–10).

One night, I had a dream. In the dream, I was standing in my church sanctuary, and I had around my waist long cords, electrical cords with plugs on the end of each cord. As I looked around the sanctuary, I noticed wall outlets on every wall—the same number of cords and outlets. I felt that if I could plug into every outlet, I would have a power in my life that I've never experienced before. I plugged into every outlet on the north wall and turned to begin the same on the south wall. I was filled with the excitement of the possibility of what this "new power" would bring to my life. As I began to plug into the south wall outlets, when I got to within an inch of plugging in, I felt the plugs on the north wall falling to the floor. How frustrating this was! So close! What seemed to be in my grasp became an *impossible task*! Right before I was about to scream "I give up!" I heard a voice behind me say, "Nothing is impossible with God!" I turned around and it was Jesus! I noticed He only had one cord coming from His heart. It was a very short cord, about an inch long. He said to me, "Apart from *me, you* can do nothing!"

I looked down at my chest where my heart was—there was an outlet. Jesus said, "Come unto me and I will give you rest." I walked up to Him. He reached out and hugged me. His heart cord plugged into my heart outlet. Suddenly, the whole world became different to me. I realized what Jesus had done for me; and if I let Him be my source, my power, my life, I would discover everything I'd been looking for my entire life. Suddenly, I felt *complete* lacking

nothing because Jesus's life was my life. This is your new life in Christ. You are *in Christ*; that's your new identity.

Begin to dream with God about your new identity. Read your Bible with a new understanding that you are in Christ. You live every day in Christ. Believe that you are *perfect* (mature) and *complete* lacking nothing (James 1:4); that you have the mind of Christ. You are complete in Him! There's no more coming! You have it all! God gives you everything up front and then the Holy Spirit teaches you what you already have. You are filled with the fullness of the godhead—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. You are never going to be more righteous than you are right now if you're born-again.

God wants you to *dream* with Him. Especially now that you can see what Jesus has provided. Dream about things like,

Fullness: that means there's no more coming. The only *more* is the understanding of what you have already been given.

All Things: when God says "all things" over and over in His Word, I think He means *all things*!

Complete: that you are *complete* in Him. That means finished. That means we're not cleaning you up along the way, but it's done! You are a new creation. You are the righteousness of God in Christ. You are never going

> to become more righteous! You are *in Christ*; that's your *new identity*. Jesus is your righteousness. "Christ in You," that's your *new destiny*. Jesus wants to live "His life" through you!

The Apostle Paul saw this, that's why he said, "For me, to live *is Christ*!" Not to be Christlike, but to let Jesus live His life through him. That's why we have to dream with God. He will begin to give you dreams and open-eye visions of what is now possible for you. In Exodus 7:1, God was trying to get Moses to "see himself" like God sees him. He said to Moses, "See, I've made you like God to Pharaoh." There was nothing to see, but God was wanting Moses to play out the movie in his head, like a daydream.

In Joshua 6:1, God said to Joshua, "See, I've given Jericho into your hands!" There was nothing to see with the human eye, but God wanted him to see who he was, with God. Well, we have the best of all situations; we carry the presence of God in us wherever we go. We have *authority* and *power* in His name. I'm not the *healer*, but I do carry Him around so when I lay hands on sick people they do get healed in Jesus's name!

Jesus said, "I will *never* leave you or forsake you." He's given us *all things* for a purpose so that He could live His life through us. Second Corinthians 1:20 says, "For all the promises of God in Him are Yes, and in Him Amen, to the glory of God through us."

Through us! *All* the promises are yes and amen to the glory of God *but they happen through us*! When I began

to meditate on what it meant to be filled with the fullness of God and when I began to realize I'm complete in Him, that ended the performance battle for me!

It's not about what I do—I could never keep it all going. I'd work on *this* and something else would be lacking. I'd work on *that*, then I would sense the enemy telling me that wasn't enough. But once I began to see what I'm sharing in this book, I found a *peace* and *joy*, and fulfillment of being in Christ, like I've never had all these many years.

Here's a list of Scriptures to meditate and dream over. Come back to these often, realize every word is true of you. Have you ever wondered why so many Christians give up and why so many pastors burn out and quit the ministry? Look at these,

> *Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light.* (Matthew 11:28–30)

All Things

Pastor Ross, December 10, 2017

> *But Jesus looked at them and said to them, "With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible."* (Matthew 19:26)

I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me. (Philippians 4:13)

Jesus said to him, "If you can believe, all things are possible to him who believes. (Mark 9:23)

But Jesus looked at them and said, "With men, it is impossible, but not with God; for with God all things are possible. (Mark 10:27)

So Jesus said to them, "Because of your unbelief; for assuredly, I say to you, if you have faith as a mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there,' and it will move, and nothing will be impossible for you." (Matthew 17:20)

But He said, "The things which are impossible with men are possible with God." (Luke 18:27)

Therefore, I say to you, whatever things you ask when you pray, believe that you receive them, and you will have them. (Mark 11:24)

And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those

who *are the called according to His purpose.* (Romans 8:28)

And I will pray the Father, and He will give you another Helper, that He may abide with you forever—the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees Him nor knows Him; but you know Him, for He dwells with you and will be in you. I will not leave you orphans; I will come to you. "A little while longer and the world will see Me no more, but you will see Me. Because I live, you will live also. At that day you will know that I am in My Father, and you in Me, and I in you. He who has My commandments and keeps them, it is he who loves Me. And he who loves Me will be loved by My Father, and I will love him and manifest Myself to him." Judas (not Iscariot) said to Him, "Lord, how is it that You will manifest Yourself to us, and not to the world?" Jesus answered and said to him, "If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word; and My Father will love him, and We will come to him and make Our home with him. He who does not love Me does not keep My words; and the word which you hear is not Mine but the Father's who sent Me. These things I have spoken to you while being present with you. But the Helper, the Holy Spirit,

whom the Father will send in My name, He will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all things that I said to you. Peace I leave with you, My peace I give to you; not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid." (John 14:16–27)

I still have many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now. However, when He, the Spirit of truth, has come, He will guide you into all truth; for He will not speak on His own authority, but whatever He hears He will speak; and He will tell you things to come. He will glorify Me, for He will take of what is Mine and declare it to you. All things that the Father has are Mine. Therefore, I said that He will take of Mine and declare it to you. (John 16:12–15)

Grace and peace be multiplied to you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord, as His divine power has given to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of Him who called us by glory and virtue. (2 Peter 1:2–3)

Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers. (3 John 2)

And He put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be head over all things to the church, which is His body, the fullness of Him who fills all in all. (Ephesians 1:22–23)

For in Him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily; and you are complete in Him, who is the head of all principality and power. (Colossians 2:9–10)

Love has been perfected among us in this: that we may have boldness in the day of judgment; because as He is, so are we in this world. (1 John 4:17)

And God is able to make all grace abound toward you, that you, always having all sufficiency in all things, may have an abundance for every good work. (2 Corinthians 9:8)

To me, who am less than the least of all the saints, this grace was given, that I should preach among the Gentiles, the unsearchable riches of Christ, and to make all see what is the fellowship of the mystery, which from the beginning of the ages has been hidden in God who created all things through Jesus Christ; to the intent that now the manifold wisdom of God might be made known by the church to the principalities and powers in

the heavenly places, according to the eternal purpose which He accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord, in whom we have boldness and access with confidence through faith in Him. Therefore, I ask that you do not lose heart at my tribulations for you, which is your glory. For this reason I bow my knees to the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, from whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named, that He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with might through His Spirit in the inner man, that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith; that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may be able to comprehend with all the saints what is the width and length and depth and height—to know the love of Christ which passes knowledge; that you may be filled with all the fullness of God. Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us, to Him be glory in the church by Christ Jesus to all generations, forever and ever. Amen. (Ephesians 3:8–21)

Discussion Time—Chapter 6

1. Discuss how our perception of God, our prayer time needs to change now that we see "He's given us all things."
2. Discuss the "impossible task of performance."
3. Discuss how abiding in Him is all that is necessary. For apart from Him we can't do anything.
4. Read and discuss the "All Things" sheet. Meditate on it and about your new life *in Christ*. What must I see *now* that He's given us *all things*?

Chapter 7

Seeing Yourself Through New Eyes

Have you ever meditated on Ephesians 3:20? "Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly, abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us." Have you ever paid attention to the last part? *According to the power that works in us.* God wants to work in and through our lives in ways that the Christian has rarely thought of.

We rarely thought about it. I believe because of the way we've seen ourselves according to the lie the enemy has told us, rather than the truth of what the Word of God actually says. But! We are coming alive to our new identity and we're realizing who we really are in Christ.

Our identity is simply this: You are 100 percent righteous, right now as a born-again believer in Jesus. You will never become more righteous than you are right now. Did you get that? You will never become more righteous than you are right now! Even though you are one hundred percent righteous, you're learning just how righteous you already are, but you never realized it.

You are 100 percent *holy*, but you're still growing. You're 100 percent *blameless*, but your conduct, your attitudes and actions are catching up! Again, you are there, but you never realized it. But thanks be to God, you are not your performance! We are *growing* in the knowledge of who God says in His Word—who we already are. We are learning about our new identity just how saved, just how righteous, just how complete, just how full we already are!

> *For in Him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily; and you are complete in Him, who is the head of all principality and power.* (Colossians 2:9–10)

The enemy wants to keep you down. He wants to discourage you. He wants to rob you of your purpose of who you are in Christ. He wants to make you feel like you're always not quite good enough to be used by God. Always not good enough, not spiritual enough (whatever that means). The enemy wants to make you feel like there's no difference between your life and those who don't even know God. But that's a lie! A huge lie!

The Holy Spirit's job is to step into your life and show you the very place where the enemy is lying to you. He wants you to learn by experience, who you are in Christ. It's called *favor*. He comes with a Word for you. He brings the grace of God (the empowering presence). He brings

a promise from the Word. He surrounds you with other believers. Peter reminds us in 2 Peter 1:2–4:

> *Grace and peace be multiplied to you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord, as His divine power has given to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of Him who called us by glory and virtue, by which have been given to us exceedingly great and precious promises, that through these you may be partakers of the divine nature, having escaped the corruption that is in the world through lust.*

Grace and peace are *multiplied* to us! He's given us *all things* that pertain to *life* and *godliness*. He comes with great and precious promises, that through these, you may be partakers of the divine nature! It's in those very places where the enemies plan is to bring you down, where your greatest growth, your strongest identity in Christ is developed. Grace and peace get multiplied to us in those times.

Not long ago, I paid off my home. I was looking forward to using my old house payment in new ways, maybe even having some fun or plan a trip away somewhere I've never been. My wife came to me one morning and said very emotionally, "Every faucet in this house is leaking! I can't even get the kitchen faucet to shut off anymore!" I was offended because I knew I should have (but didn't) fix it long ago, but I was also really upset by the fact I wasn't

going to be able to use the house payment money the way I was planning.

I am not a very handy guy, but I figured how to get the top of the faucet off and saw there was a screw on the top. I thought, *I'll tighten that screw and that should stop the drip*. I tightened the screw and it didn't stop but got worse! Well, I got mad and turned the screwdriver around and beat that faucet until it stopped leaking. Well now, it didn't leak, but would it work? I saw that I had broken the main part in half. So, when I tried to turn it on now, it wouldn't shut off! In my anger and disappointment, I cussed at it (that always helps)! My wife heard me and said, "I can't believe you just said that" (that always helps also).

I felt terrible! I thought, *Wow! Where am I, really?* I went to bed that night after apologizing to my wife for my behavior. While lying there, I said, "Lord, I'm sorry for the way I was behaving today." Immediately, the Holy Spirit spoke to be in a strong way and said, "Nothing's changed!" He said, "You're still a new creation; you're still the righteousness of God in Christ. You were *acting*, pretending to be who you use to be in your old nature. But that's NOT who you are!" I felt so free at that moment. I didn't have to start over; I didn't have to hide it. I didn't have to perform in any way. I just had to see in that very hurtful time, where the enemy meant to discourage me, that the Holy Spirit by the grace of God showed me there really is, therefore, now *no condemnation* for those who are in Christ Jesus.

> *There is, therefore, now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not*

> *walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit. For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has made me free from the law of sin and death. For what the law could not do in that it was weak through the flesh, God did by sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, on account of sin: He condemned sin in the flesh.* (Romans 8:1–3)

Note that verse 3 says, "For what the law could not do in that it was weak through the flesh, God did!" He did it by sending His Son! Hebrews 4:16 says, "Let us, therefore, come boldly to the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need." Come boldly to the throne of grace where you will find mercy and grace in your time of need. Grace and peace get multiplied to you. So how do you see yourself in these times? What is your first reaction to stumbling? What do you say and how do you treat others in those times?

The concept for the word *grace* is hard for Christians to give to others. We think grace needs to be *balanced* with rules. I think it's because of the definition of grace that most Christians believe, which is *undeserved* favor. The word "undeserved" means you did something wrong but we're going to love you anyway. If grace means undeserved favor, then Jesus never had any because He lived a perfect life. That's why I so love Graham Cooke's definition: "Grace is the empowering presence that enables me to become the person that He sees when He looks at me."

Christians are excellent at telling people that they can't earn their salvation, it's a gift. But once they get saved, we put all these rules and regulations on them. This is the ultimate "bait and switch." We think once they get saved now, we need to teach them grace plus the rules! Because we've not been taught true freedom in Christ. We think salvation was a gift, but now you need to work on this. You don't get freedom from sin by focusing on sin. You don't become righteous by focusing on your behavior. Then the Gospel becomes "do the best you can and Jesus makes up the difference!" This is NOT the Gospel! That is performance Christianity, and it's a demonic curse!

The Gospel is
when Jesus died, your old sinful nature died with Him;
when Jesus rose, in "newness of life," you rose with Him;
you are a new creation;
you are now born-again;
you are now the righteousness of God in Christ—it's a gift.

Read Romans 6 and 2 Corinthians 5:17 and 21.

In the Old Covenant, it was all about your behavior. In the New Testament (Covenant), it's all about who you are in Christ—*not* your behavior!

Ask yourself these questions:

1. How would I want to be treated when I'm a *sinner* coming to church for the first time?

2. How would I like to be treated by other Christians when I stumble?
3. How would I like other Christians to treat me when they find out about my past?

Here's another personal story. A man named Roger and his wife, Pinky, started coming to our church. They were both Christians. Roger got saved in prison after doing twenty-five years for robbing a bank and killing a police officer. (Tough stuff). Roger believed he was a new creation, that he was not the same man who did those things. So let me ask you, when does Roger become acceptable to you? When do you begin to see him as God does? When do you begin to treat him as a "brother in Christ"?

Who thinks, "Well he has to *earn* my trust"? Let me ask you, what about Paul in the Bible who used to persecute Christians, allowing them to be killed? What if the demoniac started coming to your church? Yeah! The naked guy who Jesus himself cast out a legion of demons? You ladies, what if the woman caught in adultery started coming to your church, how would she be accepted?

Now trade places with Roger, Paul, the demoniac, and the woman caught in adultery, Jesus rolled all the laws of the Old Covenant, 611 of them, into 2:

> *And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, with all your mind, and with all your strength—is the first commandment. And the second, like it, is this: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself."*

> *There is no other commandment greater than these.* (Mark 12:30–31)

Listen, I must admit that I too struggle at times. But you can't be saved by grace and then perfected by your performance. One night, the Holy Spirit woke me up out of a sound sleep and said, "Therefore, we regard NO man according to the flesh." I lay there thinking I know I've heard that, but where? It's 2 Corinthians 5:16: "Therefore, from now on, we regard no one according to the flesh. Even though we have known Christ according to the flesh, yet now we know Him, thus no longer." This is right before the verses that teach us our identity in righteousness.

Once a person is born- gain, we are to see them and ourselves as God sees us. We need to see everyone through the eyes of Jesus. But it begins with us seeing ourselves like Christ. The Bible says, "We overcame evil with good," (Romans 12:21). "It's the kindness of God that leads to repentance," (Romans 2:4). "Where sin abounds, grace much more abounds" (Romans 5:20).

Many Christians who are trying to help the Holy Spirit can destroy the *hope* that the Gospel brings by trying to focus on performance. Let's ask the Holy Spirit to open our *spiritual eyes*. That from now on, we regard no one according to the flesh, according to their past, according to even their *now* behavior. But let us see what they cannot see. What's that? It's called "calling out the gold." It's a prophetic way of seeing what God has done and is doing in them and us. It's the church saying words of edification, exhortation, and comfort to them. Focusing on who they

really are and *not* on their performance. It's treating others the way that we all want to be treated. It's seeing *ourselves* and *others* through new eyes! Then we can step into our new ministry as ambassadors of reconciliation.

> *For the love of Christ compels us, because we judge thus: that if One died for all, then all died; and He died for all, that those who live should live no longer for themselves, but for Him who died for them and rose again.*
>
> *Therefore, from now on, we regard no one according to the flesh. Even though we have known Christ according to the flesh, yet now we know Him thus no longer. Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new. Now, all things are of God, who has reconciled us to Himself through Jesus Christ, and has given us the ministry of reconciliation, that is, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not imputing their trespasses to them, and has committed to us the word of reconciliation.*
>
> *Now then, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were pleading through us: we implore you on Christ's behalf, be reconciled to God. For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might*

become the righteousness of God in Him. (2 Corinthians 5:14–21)

Many pastors, teachers, and Christians who want to disciple others use what I call the "shotgun approach." We *see* and *hear* a need so we *teach* or *preach* according to that need. We think *this* is going to fix them. Most Christians have a wonderful love for others and just want the best for them. But trying to "fix people" is not the Gospel. In fact, it's the complete opposite of what we should be doing. In 1 Corinthians 15:56–57, it says, "The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ."

Trying to fix people is the fastest way to burn out. It's not our job to fix people!

The "strength of sin" is the Law! Working on trying to fix ourselves is what gives *sin* its strength. For example, we all know if we've ever tried to go on a diet, that the thought of I can never eat *that* again (cake, french fries, etc.) what happens? It stirs up our appetite, so does sin. It makes it all more tempting to where I think, "I'd better eat cake and fries before I go on this diet!"

Romans 7:8 says, "Apart from the law, sin is dead." When I focus on my health, instead of wrong foods, when I meditate on the fact that I'm free to choose to know that "all things are lawful, but not all things are helpful" (1 Corinthians 10:23). Then I'm set free. In other words, I can eat anything (no law) but it's not going to help me walk in ever increasing health like I want it to. Romans

6:11 says, "Likewise you also, reckon yourselves to be dead indeed to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

When I change my focus from sin or keeping the law or trying to do better, be better. If I focus on who I am because of Jesus and the freedom I have, it takes my thoughts away from the law (which strengthens sin). It takes me into *vision* of what my new life can be like. It gives me better thoughts to meditate on. The Bible says, "Without a vision people cast off restraint." They give up because they think it depends on their behavior, but when they discover their new identity in Christ, they see themselves already fixed and Jesus did it! Then, "Out of the abundance of the heart, the mouth speaks," (Luke 6:45) they now have *hope*.

Now, don't get me wrong, your sin does matter to God, but not for the reasons we think. The reason it matters to God is it's not who you are. That's why you feel bad. Why you feel weird. You're acting, pretending like someone you no longer are. You are a saint, not a sinner. It had nothing to do with you working on your behavior or performance, it was all Jesus!

So instead of trying to use the "shotgun approach" on people which hits a few and misses most, instead of reading books on "how to fix people" which is an industry that thrives on keeping you broken. Instead, of flying here and there attending conferences and revival meetings hoping to discover the "next big thing," the next "hot topic." For the rest of your life, teach people their identity in Christ! Tell them the wonderful good news of the Gospel. Tell them both halves, tell them what Jesus did and how they can become truly set free!

Weave this into every message, every conversation you have for the rest of your life. Share and listen as they tell you their stories of hurt and woundedness. It doesn't matter who you're talking to— Christian or not. We're all made in the image of God. We're all broke because of "sins curse." We're all looking for wholeness because we *feel* so broken. *Until* we come to the realization of just how *free* Jesus *paid* for us to be! The Gospel is "rigged" because of the heart of the Father and the faithfulness of Jesus!

So for the rest of your life, share this wonderful truth of the Gospel and our new identity in Christ. Soon you will hear new believers declare, "I'm born again!" You will also hear precious Christians who have walked with God—thirty, forty, fifty, or sixty years—find such freedom. They will begin to say with wonderful joy and confidence, "I've been born again, again!"

Discussion Time—Chapter 7

1. Where, in what areas, do I need to let the Holy Spirit bring the *upgrades* to my thinking?
2. Where do I need to change the way I see myself?
3. Discus what happens if I blow it?
4. Discuss how I treat those around me and those who haven't yet become a born-again believer?
5. Discuss how trying to "fix" people leads to a fastest way to a burnout.
6. Discuss what it means to become an ambassador of reconciliation.
7. Discuss how do you want to treat everyone now that you see the true Gospel?

Testimonies

- Reason why you should read the book—take a moment and come up with a definition of what your identity in Christ is. Now erase it from your memory because it's not accurate. At least that would be my story. I grew up in the church but didn't come to understand my true identity until I turned fifty-six years old. I wish I knew what I know now forty years ago. I promise you this, if you read this book you won't be the same again. Money-back guarantee.
- One hundred percent guaranteed God stock—with perks of regret-free, purposeful, joyful living, new eyes and mercy of heart.
- When I accepted the Lord some forty years ago, I had no idea that I was "righteousness" or that I was in Christ just as He was in me. Frankly, I didn't know I had a thing called a "new identity." I didn't realize that *all* things had become new, and I struggled for years living on half of the gospel (saved). I thank the Lord for Pastor Ross's teaching us about who we really are and now I understand that once saved we have a new identity, it's like being born-again, again!

- I have sat under Pastor Ross's leadership for many years, and thanks to his patience and persistence, I have grown in my relationship with the Lord. It wasn't until he opened my eyes to my righteousness, according to Romans 5:17–19, that I could feel worthy of God's love. I was truly set free from the heavy cloud that hung over me due to the guilt and shame that I was hanging on to because of the issues in my past. I thank Jesus for my new identity in Him, and Pastor Ross for helping me to realize it.
- Dear reader, the knowledge you will learn through the Holy Spirit in this book is nothing short of amazing. You will learn your identity in Christ; you will be given hope that will birth new revelation and understanding of God's Word. No longer striving for good works or performance, but rather living in the free gift that God has placed in every believer, and that is the gift of righteousness. This is just the tip of the iceberg as to the knowledge Pastor Ross will bring to your understanding as you read this wonderful book. You will find a relationship with your Maker instead of religious burdens you can't live up to.

Notes

About the Author

Ross Lanphere has been a born-again Christian for forty-two years. He was a youth pastor for nineteen of those years. He wrote a youth leader training manual called *Source Seminar* while employed by the International Church of the Foursquare Gospel and Life Pacific College. For the last twenty-four years, Ross has been senior pastor of Family Life Center Foursquare Church in Coeur d'Alene, Idaho. Ross has been married to his wife, Peggy, for forty-seven years. They have three children and five grandchildren.

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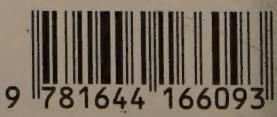

If you have been a Christian for a while, I have good news! ***Born Again, Again*** was how I felt as I discovered my true identity in Christ. Reading this book will change how you see God and how you see yourself. Discover what so many are saying about their new life in Christ: "I feel like I have been born again, again!"

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